

Serving Mainland China's High-Net-Worth Households from Hong Kong

A Segment-Led, Role-Play-Grounded Cross-Border Digital Strategy Through End-2027

Executive summary

The commercial prize is larger than it has ever been and the legal path to it is narrower than it has ever been. Hong Kong overtook Switzerland in 2026 to become the world's largest cross-border wealth booking centre with roughly US\$2.9 trillion of cross-border assets, growing 10.7% in a year, on the strength of mainland Chinese flows ([Reuters](#), [BCG](#)). In the same twelve months, Beijing closed the digital acquisition channel that most institutions had quietly relied on. CSRC Circular No. 28 of 22 May 2026 prohibits overseas institutions without a mainland licence from marketing, soliciting, opening accounts, handling orders or moving funds inside the mainland, with a two-year rectification window to approximately May 2028 ([King & Wood Mallesons](#), [Reuters](#)). NFRA Announcement No. 9 of 2026, effective 30 September 2026, makes unlicensed online marketing of overseas financial products to mainland residents an illegal financial activity and forbids disguising it as investor education ([NFRA](#), [Caixin](#)).

Nine role-played segment lives, built on published survey and occupation data, converge on one structural finding: mainland high-net-worth demand is intention-rich and holding-poor, and the binding constraint is almost never product appetite or digital literacy. It is the funding rail and the point of legal contact. Insurance intention runs at 57% of surveyed high-net-worth individuals against 28% current ownership; offshore bank savings and wealth management 50% against 20%; offshore equities 46% against 17% ([YF Life · Hurun offshore allocation whitepaper](#)). The gap is not a marketing gap. It is a plumbing gap.

The strategy that follows therefore inverts conventional digital thinking. Acquisition must be moved onto Hong Kong soil or onto non-mainland-facing surfaces; the Hong Kong mobile app becomes the sole system of record and the only place transactions occur; the WeChat Service Account is demoted to a brand and post-sale service surface with no funnel function; WeCom is used for servicing continuity but never for advice, because session archiving is unavailable to overseas-registered WeCom entities ([Tencent WeCom help centre](#), [WeCom developer documentation](#)); and the compliant growth pool is redefined as Hong Kong-resident, mainland-origin cohorts — talent-scheme migrants, investment migrants, students and international-school families — plus the Wealth Management Connect closed loop and the physical Hong Kong visit.

By 31 December 2027 the institution should be able to state, with evidence, that it operates three legally distinct books of cross-border business on one digital spine, that it acquires the majority of its mainland-origin clients through pre-arrival digital journeys completed in Hong Kong within a single visit, that currency and payments — not investment products — carry its scale, and that its advice, reporting and tax-transparency features are the reason clients consolidate rather than diversify away. Section 12 states the target end-state in falsifiable terms.

Part 1 — Method

The analysis proceeded in four steps, deliberately bottom-up.

Step one: build the population frame from published wealth statistics. Household counts, wealth concentration and occupation mix were taken from the BEA · Hurun Wealth Report 2025 and the Hurun-Bain occupational cuts, rather than assumed.

Step two: segment on the two variables that determine what is legally possible, not on wealth band alone. Wealth band determines product eligibility; residency and identity status determine channel legality. A RMB50m entrepreneur in Dongguan and a RMB50m entrepreneur who has taken Hong Kong residency under the Top Talent Pass Scheme are, for digital design purposes, entirely different customers.

Step three: role-play each segment as a lived narrative — a working year, a specific trigger event, the actual sequence of frustrations — and extract cross-border needs from the narrative rather than from a product catalogue. Each vignette is a synthesis constructed from the published behavioural, regulatory and friction evidence cited throughout this report; the vignettes are analytical instruments, not interviews with named individuals.

Step four: aggregate the extracted needs into clusters, derive design laws, and only then design channels, products, data architecture and roadmap. Where a need has no legal rail, the strategy says so and parks it rather than designing an illegal journey.

Part 2 — The population frame

The pool is consolidating, not growing

Greater China households with RMB6m or more in total wealth numbered 5.06 million at the start of 2025, down 1.3% year on year; RMB10m+ households 2.005 million, down 2.9%; RMB100m+ households 126,000, down 3.1%; and US\$30m+ households 83,000, down 3.5% ([Hurun](#)). Mainland-only figures were 4.083 million, 1.625 million, 106,000 and 70,000 respectively. Total wealth held by these households reached RMB145 trillion, down 3.3%, with RMB100m+ households holding RMB84 trillion, or 58% of the total ([The Standard](#)).

The strategic reading is that household counts are flat to falling while concentration rises. Growth will not come from a rising tide of new millionaires. It will come from share of wallet within a stable, increasingly concentrated pool that is actively re-allocating offshore, and from mobility cohorts physically relocating into Hong Kong.

Who these people actually are

Occupation mix matters more than wealth band for need discovery. Among RMB10m+ high-net-worth individuals, business owners are 53%, senior corporate managers — the "gold-collar" cohort — 35%, professional investors 9% and property investors 3%. Among the ultra-high-net-worth tier the mix shifts sharply: owners 80%, professional investors 16%, property investors 4% ([Hurun](#)).

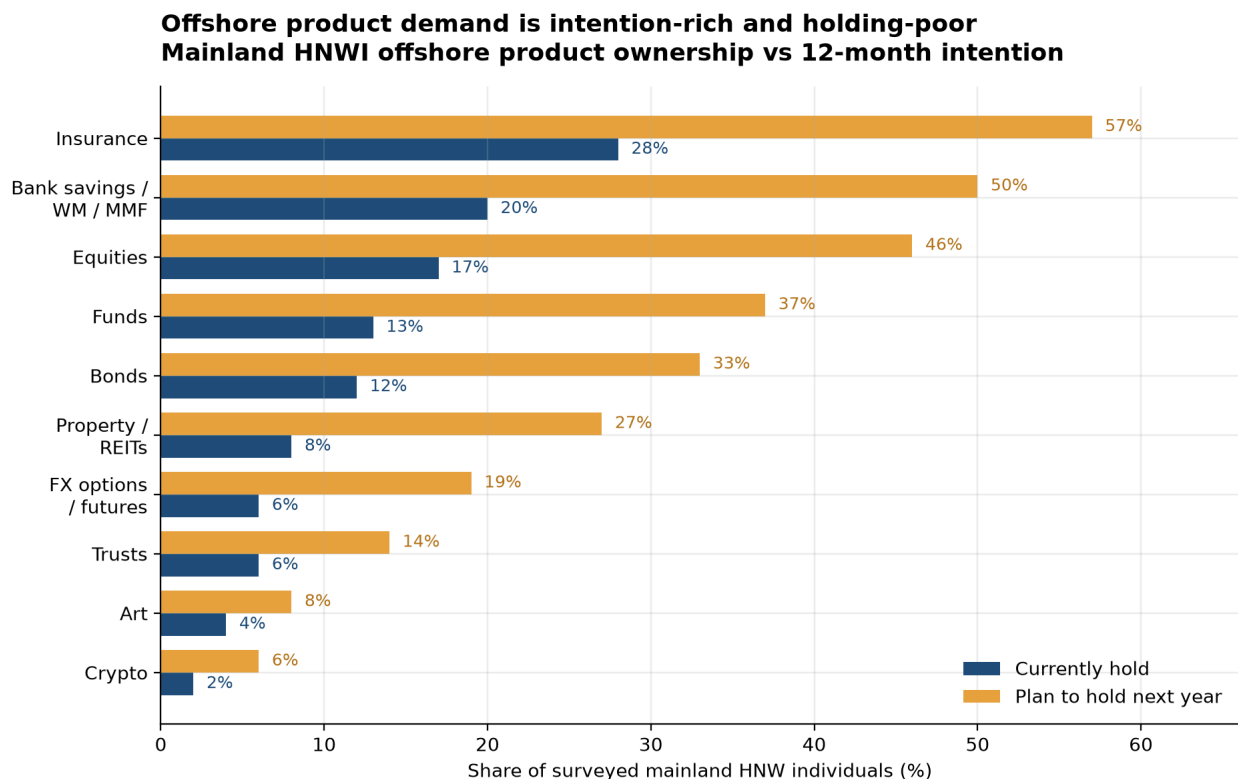
A finer cut from the Bain · China Merchants Bank private wealth study distinguishes first-generation entrepreneurs at 20%, second-generation inheritors 17%, dual-status shareholder-executives 14%, professional managers 15%, professionals 9% and homemakers 13%, with 49% of high-net-worth individuals under the age of 40 ([Bain · CMB China Private Wealth Report](#)). The 2023 edition remains the most recent citable version of this occupational breakdown.

Two implications follow. First, the modal client is younger than the private-banking stereotype and expects app-native service. Second, roughly a third of the pool are salaried executives whose wealth is in equity compensation, which creates a completely different cross-border need set — currency conversion, vesting, offshore custody, tax reporting — from the entrepreneur's need set of trade receipts, succession and asset segregation.

Where the money wants to go

Offshore allocation is 15% of investable assets on average, rising to 26% for ultra-high-net-worth households and around 30% for those above RMB50m. Hong Kong is the leading destination at 52% of offshore intent, and Oliver Wyman estimates 30% to 40% of Chinese offshore wealth flows through Hong Kong ([Oliver Wyman](#)).

Stated purposes for offshore allocation are diversification 62%, access to assets unavailable onshore 56%, children's education 48%, higher returns 42% and privacy 40% ([YF Life · Hurun](#)). Education and privacy sit alongside return-seeking, which means an offer built purely on investment performance will address less than half the motivation.



Source: YF Life · Hurun HNWI offshore asset allocation whitepaper (Dec 2025), n=500

Directional intentions for 2026 reinforce the picture: net positive intentions for gold at +15%, offshore investment +7%, funds +6% and insurance +6%, against A-shares at -3% and domestic property at -21%; within offshore allocations, US equities +17%, Hong Kong equities +10% and

stablecoins +4% ([Hurun](#)). Gold's prominence is consistent with record Chinese retail investment demand reported by the [World Gold Council](#).

The generational clock

An estimated RMB21 trillion will transfer within ten years, RMB46 trillion within twenty and RMB77 trillion within thirty ([Hurun](#), [South China Morning Post](#)). UBS reports a surge in mainland family trust formation as founders plan transfers ([Caixin](#)). Hong Kong single family offices reached 3,384 by end-2025, up 25% in two years, with 1,095 managing more than US\$100m ([Deloitte](#), [South China Morning Post](#)).

How they actually research money

Xiaohongshu is the leading information channel for 61% of the surveyed cohort, average age 36, with WeChat Channels at 32%; DeepSeek and Doubao are the dominant AI assistants ([YF Life · Hurun](#)). Purchase channels for offshore products skew heavily onshore: domestic banks 68%, domestic brokers 51%, mainland branches of foreign institutions 42%. Offshore insurance is bought by travelling to Hong Kong and signing with a locally licensed intermediary in 64% of cases.

Digital-versus-human preference is not uniform. Bain's study finds account opening 40% digital-led and understanding an offering 51% digital-led, but problem resolution 46% human-led and advice 41% human-led ([Bain · CMB](#)). The design consequence is a hybrid: digital for discovery, eligibility, document capture and execution; human for advice, exceptions and remediation.

Part 3 — The 2026 regulatory reset

Any strategy written before May 2026 is obsolete. Four changes redefine the perimeter.

CSRC Circular No. 28 (22 May 2026), issued with seven other agencies. Overseas institutions lacking a mainland licence may not market, solicit, open accounts, handle orders or transfer funds within the mainland. A two-year rectification period to approximately May 2028 permits servicing and orderly withdrawal but not growth. In-person account opening in Hong Kong is not prohibited. The treatment of reverse enquiry remains unresolved ([King & Wood Mallesons](#), [Sidley, Hauzen](#)).

Enforcement was immediate and expensive. Futu, Tiger and Longbridge were fined approximately US\$330m in aggregate, with Futu's penalty at RMB1.85bn, and halted mainland-investor onboarding and position-adding from mid-June 2026 ([law.asia](#), [Reuters](#)). Demand did not disappear; it moved offline and southbound, producing visible queues at Hong Kong brokers and banks ([Reuters](#), [Caixin](#)).

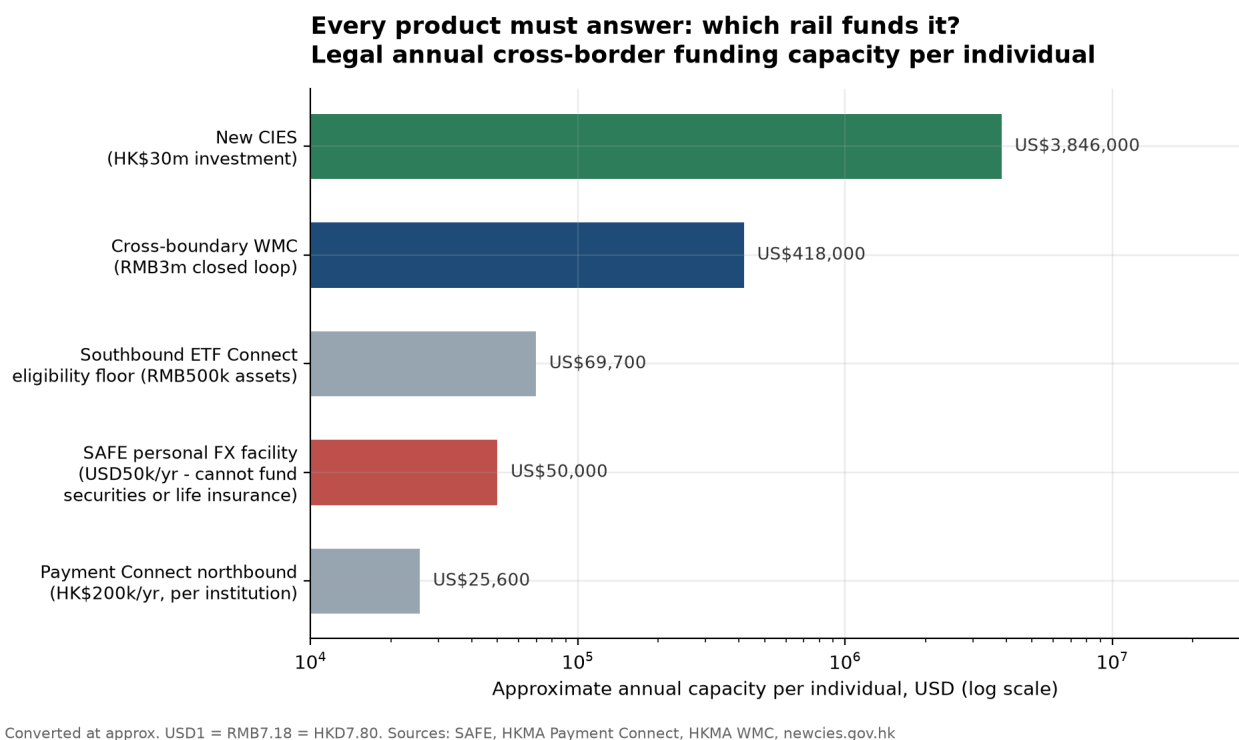
NFRA Announcement No. 9 of 2026 (published 21 April 2026, effective 30 September 2026). Online marketing of overseas financial products to mainland residents without a mainland licence is an illegal financial activity; platforms may not facilitate it; and marketing may not be disguised as investor education ([NFRA](#)). This provision specifically kills the "educational content funnel" tactic that many institutions had adopted as a workaround.

Hong Kong-side tightening in parallel. SFC circular 26EC29 of 22 May 2026, with a matching HKMA circular, requires closure of accounts opened with forged documents, closure of zero-balance dormant investment accounts, written client declarations that offshore funding is lawful, and settlement only through Hong Kong-licensed banks in the client's own name ([SFC](#), [HKMA](#)). Major banks tightened investment-account rules within days ([Reuters](#)), and the HKMA subsequently confirmed that mainland customers can still open accounts in Hong Kong ([South China Morning Post](#)).

Tax transparency became operational. A 20% individual income tax applies to offshore stock gains computed per transaction without loss offset ([Caixin](#), [Caixin](#)); CRS data has been integrated into enforcement systems ([Caixin](#), [WTS](#)); MOF/STA Announcement No. 21 of 2026 extends 20% IIT treatment to offshore trusts ([Morgan Lewis](#), [Caixin](#)); and enforcement extended to gains on offshore and Hong Kong insurance policies ([The Standard](#)).

The legal rails that remain

Rail	Capacity and status	What it can fund
Cross-boundary Wealth Management Connect 2.0	Individual quota RMB3m since 26 February 2024; residency test eased to 2 years or RMB400k income over 3 years; aggregate RMB150bn each way; 14 securities firms authorised (PwC , KPMG)	Southbound deposits, low-to-high-risk non-complex products, non-complex SFC-authorized Greater China equity funds
SAFE personal FX facility	US\$50,000 per person per year (SAFE)	Travel, education, living costs. Explicitly not overseas property, securities, life insurance or investment-type participating insurance under Huifa [2016] No. 36
Payment Connect (FPS–IBPS)	Live 22 June 2025; northbound HKD10,000 per day and HKD200,000 per year per person per institution; approximately 315 million addressable users (HKMA , South China Morning Post)	Small-value remittance, allowances, fee settlement
Southbound Stock Connect	Average daily turnover HK\$123.1bn in H1 2026 (HKEX)	Hong Kong-listed equities held onshore
Southbound Bond Connect	Quota raised from RMB500bn to RMB800bn on 7 July 2026 (HKMA , The Standard)	Offshore bonds for eligible onshore institutional and qualified channels
Mutual Recognition of Funds	Host-market cap raised from 50% to 80% from 1 January 2025 (PwC , Reuters)	Hong Kong-domiciled funds sold onshore
QDII	Cumulative quota US\$176.2bn; new quotas under consideration to widen retail access (Caixin)	Offshore securities via onshore managers
New CIES	HK\$30m total, comprising HK\$27m in permissible assets plus HK\$3m into the CIES Investment Portfolio (InvestHK)	Full Hong Kong investment shelf, plus residency



The chart makes the central design constraint visible. The everyday rail — US\$50,000 — is an order of magnitude below Wealth Management Connect, which is itself an order of magnitude below the investment-migration route. A product proposition that ignores which rail funds it is not a proposition.

Wealth Management Connect uptake demonstrates both the opportunity and the current shortfall: more than 181,000 investors and more than RMB138bn of cross-boundary remittances at end-May 2026, yet only roughly 11% of the southbound quota and 0.16% of the northbound quota utilised ([Hong Kong Government](#), [HKMA](#)). The southbound product mix rotated from roughly 98% deposits at launch to 59% deposits, 36% funds and 5% bonds. Bank menus expanded from around 160 to around 300 funds. No WMC 3.0 has been announced, although expansion beyond the Greater Bay Area has been publicly discussed ([Caixin](#)).

Insurance: the largest single flow, physically gated

Mainland Chinese visitor new insurance premiums reached HK\$62.8bn in FY2024, up 6.5%, representing 28.6% of new individual business, weighted toward whole life at approximately 59% and critical illness at 28%. The Insurance Authority suspended the disaggregated MCV data series from Q1 2025, so no comparable 2025 or 2026 figure exists ([Insurance Business](#)). Overall Hong Kong premiums rose 32.5% in the first three quarters of 2025 ([The Asset](#)).

The operating rules are strict and largely non-digital. Mainland visitors must sign in Hong Kong in person; Hong Kong intermediaries may not solicit onshore; premiums must be paid directly to the insurer; UnionPay has barred mainland cards for insurance with an investment element since 29 October 2016 ([South China Morning Post](#), [Reuters](#)); and the Insurance Authority actively pursues unlicensed selling ([Asia Insurance Review](#)). Illustration caps of 6.5% and 6% took effect in July 2025 ([Insurance Authority](#)).

One material option is opening. On 16 March 2026 the Insurance Authority announced a redefinition of the MCV category that would exclude talent-scheme migrants and PRC passport holders resident overseas, with consultation in Q2 2026 and guidelines within 2026 — potentially permitting virtual signing for those cohorts ([The Standard](#), [ComplianceOne](#)). This single change would convert a physically gated product into a digitally distributable one for precisely the cohorts identified below as the compliant growth pool.

The mobility cohorts

The new Capital Investment Entrant Scheme had drawn 3,166 applications and 1,762 approvals by 28 February 2026, with expected inflows of approximately HK\$95bn; verified assets comprised SFC-authorized funds 38.6%, equities 29.0%, investment-linked assurance schemes 9.9% and debt securities 9.5% ([LegCo](#), [InvestHK](#)). The Top Talent Pass Scheme had received more than 150,000 applications with more than 120,000 approved and over 100,000 arrivals by end-2025, with mainland applicants accounting for 94.8% of TTPS approvals, 97.9% of Quality Migrant Admission Scheme approvals and effectively all Admission Scheme for Mainland Talents and Professionals approvals ([South China Morning Post](#)).

Education flows are the third cohort. Chinese students abroad numbered 570,600 in 2025, a decade low, with average family budgets around RMB605,000 ([Caixin](#)), while mainland students account for roughly 72% of non-local students at Hong Kong universities and the non-local ceiling is rising toward 50% ([South China Morning Post](#), [Dim Sum Daily](#)). Substitution away from the United States and toward Hong Kong is the single most reliable acquisition tailwind available.

The friction that defines the opportunity

Bank of China (Hong Kong)'s Tsim Sha Tsui branch has rationed same-day account-opening tickets to about 60 per day, with queues forming from 06:00 ([Ta Kung Wen Wei](#)). Offshore renminbi deposits in Hong Kong stood at RMB1,134.7bn at end-May 2026 ([Nashnova](#)). Demand is queuing at the door. The winner is whoever removes the queue without breaching the perimeter.

Part 4 — Segmentation

Segmentation logic

Two axes govern everything.

Axis one — source and structure of wealth, which determines product need, sophistication, currency exposure and succession complexity.

Axis two — legal identity and residency status, which determines which channels may lawfully touch the client, whether onboarding can be remote, and which funding rails are available.

Wealth band is treated as a third, subordinate dimension used for shelf eligibility, not for journey design. The result is nine operational segments.

#	Segment	Approximate profile	Legal status	Primary funding rail	Priority
1	GBA manufacturer-exporter	RMB30–150m, age 50–65, Dongguan / Foshan / Zhongshan	Mainland resident, GBA-qualified	WMC + genuine trade receipts offshore	High
2	New-economy gold-collar executive	RMB10–40m, age 32–45, Shenzhen / Hangzhou / Shanghai	Mainland resident, often non-GBA	Equity compensation received offshore; US\$50k facility	High
3	Second-generation inheritor / returnee	Family RMB100m+, age 24–35, HK-educated	Frequently HK resident or student	Family offshore structures	High
4	Talent-scheme migrant (TTPS / QMAS)	RMB10–50m, age 28–40	Hong Kong resident	Hong Kong salary; full HK shelf	Highest
5	Investment migrant (CIES)	RMB100m+, age 42–58	Hong Kong resident via CIES	HK\$30m CIES investment	Highest
6	Protection-first affluent parent	RMB6–20m, age 35–48, tier-1 / tier-2 cities	Mainland resident, MCV	Travel to HK; insurer-direct premium	High
7	Displaced self-directed investor	RMB3–15m, age 26–38	Mainland resident	Blocked; requires in-person HK account	Medium
8	Founder in succession	RMB200m+, age 58–70, Fujian / Zhejiang / Guangdong	Mainland resident; family often multi-jurisdictional	Historic offshore holdings; trust restructuring	High
9	Cross-border e-commerce operator	RMB8–60m, age 30–42, Shenzhen / Hangzhou	Mainland resident, offshore corporate entities	Genuine offshore trading receipts	High

Segment 4 and Segment 5 are ranked highest not because they are the largest but because they are the only segments where a Hong Kong institution can lawfully run a full digital acquisition funnel.

Part 5 — Role-play: nine lives

Each vignette is written in the segment's voice, followed by the needs it surfaces and an assessment of what currently breaks.

Segment 1 — The Dongguan manufacturer-exporter

Fifty-nine years old. The factory makes power tools for three European brands and one American one. Revenue is invoiced in dollars and euros; the Hong Kong company holds the receipts because that is how it has been done since 2004. Onshore, the money is RMB and it is boring — deposit rates keep falling, the wealth management products the relationship manager at the joint-stock bank pushes have all had their expected returns cut, and the two apartments in Guangzhou have been worth less every year since 2021. What has changed is that the Hong Kong company's balance has become significant. It is not investment money that left China; it is trade money that never came in. Nobody has ever explained clearly what may be done with it. The accountant says do not mix it with personal money. The Hong Kong bank sends statements in English. There is a Wealth Management Connect account opened in 2022 that holds a single Hong Kong dollar time deposit because the process of choosing anything else required an in-branch conversation that never happened.

The residency requirement was eased, so the son, who works in Shenzhen, now also qualifies. Nobody has told either of them that.

What is genuinely wanted: a way to see the onshore RMB, the WMC southbound pot and the Hong Kong corporate account in one place; a clear answer on what the personal RMB3m may buy; a US dollar income stream that funds the daughter's postgraduate study in the UK; and a plan for what happens to the factory.

Needs surfaced: consolidated cross-boundary position view; WMC southbound product education and self-service switching; USD income generation; corporate–personal separation with clean audit trail; education funding in a third currency; succession initiation; simplified-Chinese service in a Cantonese-and-Mandarin voice channel.

What breaks today: the WMC account is a dormant deposit because switching requires a physical conversation; the corporate relationship and the personal relationship sit in different systems with different relationship managers; and nobody proactively re-tested the eased eligibility of family members. This is a servicing failure that reads as low product appetite.

Segment 2 — The Shenzhen new-economy executive

Thirty-six. Vice-president at a listed technology company. Cash salary is comfortable; the real wealth is restricted stock units in a Cayman entity listed in Hong Kong, vesting quarterly into a broker account that was opened through the company plan. Roughly RMB18m on paper, RMB4m realised.

The problems are all mechanical. When shares are sold, the proceeds are in Hong Kong dollars in a broker account, and moving them onshore means a conversation about source of funds and, since last year, a tax filing on gains at 20% per transaction with no netting of the loss on the position sold in the previous quarter. The US\$50,000 annual quota is irrelevant in the wrong direction – the money is already offshore and the question is whether to bring it back at all.

The trading app that had been used for US stocks stopped allowing new positions in June. The account still exists but is frozen in place. Colleagues have started making Saturday trips to Hong Kong to open accounts in person. Xiaohongshu is full of posts about which branch has the shortest queue and which documents to bring; half of them contradict each other.

What is genuinely wanted: an offshore custody and investment account that will not be shut down; help computing the tax position transaction by transaction; a way to hold US dollars and buy US-listed technology names without a mainland-facing app; and eventually a mortgage or education plan in Hong Kong.

Needs surfaced: offshore custody continuity and platform-risk mitigation; per-transaction tax computation and reporting export; US and Hong Kong equity access via a Hong Kong-situs account; multi-currency cash management; equity-compensation lifecycle support including vesting calendars and concentration analysis; credible, verifiable pre-arrival account-opening information.

What breaks today: the client is actively looking for a new home for offshore assets, has been displaced by enforcement, and is receiving guidance from unverified social content. This is the highest-intent, lowest-cost acquisition in the entire market, and the only lawful way to capture it is a pre-arrival digital journey completed on Hong Kong soil.

Segment 3 – The second-generation returnee

Twenty-eight. Undergraduate in Hong Kong, master's in London, back in Hong Kong now working in a corporate finance team. The family business is chemicals in Shandong; the father runs it and does not delegate. There is a BVI company, a Hong Kong company, an insurance policy taken out in 2016 with a face value nobody has explained, and a trust that a lawyer set up in 2019 and which the family has not revisited since the offshore trust tax announcement.

Personally: a Hong Kong salary, a Hong Kong Identity Card, an app-first life, and no patience for anything that requires a branch. Investment behaviour is self-directed and global – US technology, a gold ETF, some digital assets on a licensed platform, and irritation that the family's private bank relationship offers products with fee structures visible on any comparison site.

The real role is translator. When the father needs to understand what the new trust rules mean, the call comes here. When the mother wants to know whether the 2016 policy still makes sense, the call comes here. There is no institution that treats this position as a client role.

What is genuinely wanted: to be recognised as the family's operating decision-maker while the father remains the legal owner; institutional-quality answers on structures without a sales agenda; a self-directed, low-friction investment platform; and eventually the authority to consolidate.

Needs surfaced: family-role-aware permissioning and multi-generational household views; structure review and tax-impact explanation as a service; fully self-directed digital investing with transparent fees; digital asset and gold exposure through regulated channels; succession readiness diagnostics; English and Chinese parity.

What breaks today: institutional CRM models a household as an account holder plus authorised signatories, not as an influence network. The inheritor is served as a small retail client while directing a large family relationship.

Segment 4 – The talent-scheme migrant

Thirty-four. Data science lead, moved from Beijing under the Top Talent Pass Scheme fourteen months ago. Hong Kong Identity Card, Hong Kong employment contract, Hong Kong tax status, and a spouse who is still working remotely for a mainland employer. Roughly RMB22m of household wealth, most of it still onshore: a Beijing apartment being rented out, RMB4m in onshore funds, RMB2m in a bank wealth management product.

The frustrations are all seams. Salary lands in a Hong Kong account. Rent from Beijing lands onshore. Sending money either direction is a puzzle of quotas: Payment Connect works for small amounts, the annual per-institution limit is reached quickly, and larger movements mean a branch visit and a set of questions. The mainland bank app still works but increasingly asks for onshore verification that requires a mainland mobile number tied to a mainland address.

Insurance is a live question. Two children, and a critical-illness policy plus a savings policy denominated in dollars are wanted. Advisers say a mainland visitor must sign in Hong Kong, which is fine — there is residency here. But the paperwork treats the applicant as a mainland visitor anyway.

The MPF account is a mystery. So is whether to buy or keep renting. So is whether the Beijing apartment should be sold, and what that would mean for tax on both sides. What is genuinely wanted: one bank that treats a mainland-origin Hong Kong resident as a Hong Kong resident; end-to-end digital onboarding using the Hong Kong Identity Card without a branch visit; sensible cross-boundary transfer orchestration; dual-jurisdiction tax visibility; insurance that can be arranged without theatre; and a Hong Kong property plan.

Needs surfaced: fully remote onboarding for Hong Kong Identity Card holders; cross-boundary transfer orchestration across Payment Connect, the FX facility and correspondent rails with quota visualisation; USD and CNH multi-currency accounts; protection and savings insurance under the anticipated MCV redefinition; MPF consolidation; Hong Kong mortgage pre-qualification; dual-jurisdiction tax reporting; onshore asset disposal planning.

What breaks today: almost every institution routes this client into a mainland-visitor process because the customer record keys on nationality rather than residency. This is the single largest self-inflicted commercial loss identified in the analysis, and it is a data-model problem, not a regulatory one. More than 100,000 arrivals sit in this cohort.

Segment 5 — The investment migrant

Forty-nine. Sold a controlling stake in a logistics business in 2023. Applied under the new Capital Investment Entrant Scheme, placed HK\$27m in permissible assets and HK\$3m into the CIES Investment Portfolio, and received approval in principle. Two children, one at an international school in Hong Kong, one still in Shanghai. The scheme forced a set of investment decisions to be made quickly, and they were made through whichever institution processed the application fastest. Roughly 39% went into SFC-authorised funds because they were easiest to verify, 29% into Hong Kong equities, 10% into an investment-linked assurance scheme that has never been fully understood, and the balance into debt securities. Now the portfolio must be maintained under scheme conditions for years, and every action carries a compliance consequence. Reporting to the Immigration Department is a spreadsheet exercise. There is no view of whether the portfolio is appropriate for the actual objective – funding two children through university and preserving capital in dollars – as opposed to appropriate for the scheme. Simultaneously: whether to move the remaining onshore wealth, what CRS reporting has already disclosed, whether the family trust needs restructuring after the new offshore trust tax rules, and whether a family office structure makes sense.

Needs surfaced: CIES-compliant portfolio construction with automated eligibility monitoring; scheme reporting automation for immigration compliance; suitability review independent of the scheme's constraints; education funding in USD; family trust and succession restructuring; family office and private-investment access; CRS and tax-position transparency; concierge-grade digital service with named human escalation.

What breaks today: the CIES portfolio is treated as a compliance artefact rather than a managed portfolio. There is a clear, defensible product – a fully digital CIES portfolio and reporting service – that almost nobody offers as a designed proposition.

Segment 6 – The protection-first parent from Wuhan

Forty-two. Husband runs a building-materials distribution business; household wealth around RMB12m, most of it in property and the business. A day trip to Hong Kong every eighteen months or so: a multi-currency savings policy signed in 2019, a critical-illness policy in 2021, both through an agent introduced by a friend.

The reasons are not sophisticated and not about returns. The onshore critical-illness cover felt thin, the currency should not all be renminbi, and the policies are for the child.

What has been difficult is everything after signing. Premium payment cannot go on a mainland card for the savings policy, so each year involves a transfer arrangement that feels precarious. Policy documents are in traditional Chinese. The agent has changed twice. A claim was submitted in 2023 and took four months because documents had to be couriered. There is no app that shows both policies, their cash values and the premium schedule in one place.

Recently the news said tax authorities are looking at gains on Hong Kong policies.

Nobody has explained what that means.

What is genuinely wanted: a single digital view of all Hong Kong policies; reliable, legal premium payment; digital claims without couriers; plain simplified-Chinese explanations including tax; and a way to add a small savings account so the annual trip achieves more than one thing.

Needs surfaced: consolidated policy servicing app for mainland visitors; compliant premium payment orchestration; digital claims submission and status tracking; plain-language tax explanation; multi-currency savings account bundled with the insurance visit; appointment scheduling that combines insurer signing and bank account opening in one trip; document delivery in simplified Chinese.

What breaks today: the industry optimises the sale and abandons the service. The Greater Bay Area after-sales service centres remain a stated policy direction rather than a confirmed operating facility ([Greater Bay Area portal](#)). Post-sale digital servicing is permissible, unglamorous, and the cheapest available source of loyalty and cross-sell in the entire mainland-visitor franchise.

Segment 7 — The displaced self-directed investor

Thirty-one. Product manager in Shanghai, RMB5m of investable assets, self-taught, trades actively. Was a heavy user of an offshore brokerage app until June, when new positions stopped. Onshore A-share performance has been disappointing; gold has worked; US technology exposure is wanted and cannot be reached.

The reaction was to research alternatives online, which is now a legal grey area from the platform side and a factual minefield from the user side. The conclusion reached was that a physical trip to Hong Kong is required, that a bank account and a broker account are both needed, that some banks have introduced additional requirements, and that arriving without exactly the right documents means losing a day.

What is genuinely wanted: a trip that works; certainty about documents and eligibility before travelling; an account that will not be closed in six months; low-cost access to US and Hong Kong equities, gold and money market funds; and no dependence on a platform that can be switched off.

Needs surfaced: pre-arrival eligibility pre-check and document checklist; appointment booking with guaranteed slots; same-visit account activation; transparent explanation of the lawful funding path and its limits; low-cost self-directed multi-market trading; tokenised money market and gold products; explicit institutional stability messaging.

What breaks today: high intent, low ticket size, and an acquisition cost that collapses if the journey is digitised and the visit is short. This segment also carries elevated source-of-funds risk and must be filtered, not courted indiscriminately, given the declaration requirements in SFC circular 26EC29.

Segment 8 — The founder in succession

Sixty-three. Built a textile group in Fujian over thirty-two years. Group wealth beyond RMB200m across the operating company, property, an offshore holding structure and a Hong Kong-domiciled trust established in 2018. Three children: one in the business, one in Vancouver, one uninterested.

The last twelve months have been unsettling. The offshore trust tax announcement changed the assumption on which the 2018 structure was built. CRS means the Hong Kong accounts are visible. The insurance policies bought as a wealth-transfer wrapper are now within scope of tax enquiry. The private bank's answer to all of this has been to arrange a seminar.

Digital expectation is low but not zero — the WeChat account is used constantly, mostly to read forwarded articles from advisers, and their quality is unverifiable.

What is genuinely wanted: a defensible, current answer on the trust; a succession plan that survives the children's differing jurisdictions and interests; liquidity planning for the operating business; and a single institution that owns the whole problem rather than selling one piece of it.

Needs surfaced: trust and structure health-check with jurisdiction-aware tax analysis; multi-jurisdiction succession planning; family governance and next-generation preparation; family office establishment support; liquidity and business-exit planning; philanthropy; verified expert content delivered through WeChat rather than social forwards; strong human relationship with digital continuity for family members.

What breaks today: the need is advisory and the delivery is transactional. The digital contribution here is not self-service — it is proactive event detection, that is, identifying which clients hold structures affected by a rule change and triggering an outreach within days rather than at the next annual review.

Segment 9 — The cross-border e-commerce operator

Thirty-five. Sells home goods on Amazon US and Europe and on a Middle Eastern marketplace, operating from Shenzhen through a Hong Kong company and a US LLC. Platform settlements arrive in USD, EUR and GBP. Personal wealth around RMB25m, most of it accumulated offshore from genuine trade.

Daily life is currency and payments. Settlements arrive in four currencies, suppliers are paid in RMB, advertising is paid in USD, and every month involves timing conversions. Payment service providers are used because banks were slow. Personal and business money have blurred, which is a growing worry as tax enforcement tightens.

Investment need is real and unserved. Cash sits in a Hong Kong current account earning nothing. Money market funds, USD deposits, gold and equities are all wanted, and the bank's investment onboarding process asked questions that seemed designed to make it not happen.

What is genuinely wanted: multi-currency accounts with competitive conversion and API-level access; clean separation and documentation of business and personal flows; a fast route from corporate cash to yield; trade finance and receivables facilities; and confidence that offshore-earned money is being handled in a defensible way.

Needs surfaced: multi-currency corporate and personal accounts with transparent FX; API and accounting-system integration; documented source-of-funds narrative and audit trail; treasury yield products including money market funds and short-duration bonds; e-commerce receivables and trade finance; personal wealth onboarding that recognises verified corporate wealth; tax and structure advice on business-to-personal extraction.

What breaks today: this is the segment where a Hong Kong institution is on the strongest legal ground — offshore-earned funds, genuine commercial substance, no capital-account circumvention — and where banks most often lose to payment fintechs on service quality. Winning the corporate cash management relationship is also the most defensible route to the personal wealth relationship.

Part 6 — Bottom-up synthesis

Need clusters and their frequency across the nine lives

Need cluster	Segments where it appeared	Legal rail available	Digital feasibility
Multi-currency cash, CNH and FX with visible quotas	1, 2, 4, 6, 7, 9	Payment Connect, FX facility, offshore-earned funds	High — fully digital
Consolidated cross-boundary position view	1, 3, 4, 5, 6, 8	Read-only aggregation, PIPL-constrained	High, with data-residency design
Offshore custody and investment continuity	2, 3, 5, 7, 9	HK-situs account opened in person or via HKID eKYC	Medium — gated at onboarding
Tax computation, reporting and after-tax illustration	2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 8	Fully permissible as a reporting feature	High — major differentiator
Insurance arrangement and post-sale servicing	1, 3, 4, 5, 6, 8	Physically gated today; MCV redefinition pending	Low pre-sale, high post-sale

Need cluster	Segments where it appeared	Legal rail available	Digital feasibility
Education funding in a third currency	1, 2, 4, 5	FX facility, offshore assets	High
Succession, trust and structure review	1, 3, 5, 8	Advisory in HK, not solicited onshore	Medium — hybrid
Pre-arrival eligibility, documents and appointments	2, 4, 6, 7	Fully permissible	High — highest ROI
Household and family-role permissioning	1, 3, 5, 8	Permissible with consent architecture	High
Yield on idle offshore corporate cash	1, 9	Offshore-earned funds	High

Five design laws derived from the role-plays

Law one: the rail precedes the product. In six of nine lives, the product wanted was legally available and the funding path was not. Any product page that does not state which rail funds it will generate abandoned journeys and compliance incidents. The funding rail must become a first-class object in the product catalogue and in the user interface.

Law two: residency status, not nationality, must key the customer record. Segment 4 loses to competitors for a reason that is purely architectural. Mainland-origin Hong Kong residents are the only large cohort that can be acquired, advised, transacted and serviced entirely digitally, and most institutions route them into a visitor process. Fixing the identity model is the highest-return single change available.

Law three: acquisition happens on Hong Kong soil; digital compresses the visit. Circular 28 and NFRA Announcement No. 9 remove the onshore funnel; in-person account opening in Hong Kong remains permitted. The design objective is therefore to move every step that can be done remotely — eligibility, document capture, product selection, risk profiling, appointment booking — to before arrival, so the Hong Kong visit takes ninety minutes instead of a day.

Law four: post-sale servicing is the uncontested territory. Segment 6's experience is the industry norm. Servicing an existing relationship is not solicitation. It is legally safe, digitally straightforward, and currently so poor that it constitutes a differentiator on its own.

Law five: tax transparency converts a threat into a feature. With the 20% offshore gains regime, the offshore trust rules, insurance-gain enforcement and CRS integration, clients across five of nine segments need computation and documentation, not concealment. The institution that provides after-tax illustrations, per-transaction gain reports and CRS-position clarity becomes the natural consolidator.

Part 7 — Strategic architecture: three books on one spine

The strategy organises all nine segments into three legally distinct books of business, each with its own permissible channel set, sharing a single technology and data spine.

Book A — Hong Kong Resident (Segments 3, 4, 5, and migrated members of 1, 2, 8). Clients holding a Hong Kong Identity Card. Fully digital acquisition, advice, transaction and service. Remote onboarding is permissible using iAM Smart or iAM Smart+ and ICAO ePassport-based digital certificates, which the SFC recognised as acceptable non-face-to-face onboarding means in circular 25EC31 of 30 May 2025 ([SFC, iAM Smart](#)), alongside the HKMA's remote onboarding guidance ([HKMA](#)). This book is where digital ambition should be unconstrained.

Book B — GBA Closed Loop (Segments 1, 6, and part of 9). Wealth Management Connect southbound, operated with mainland partner banks and securities firms, funded within the RMB3m quota and settled through the designated closed loop. Digital experience is delivered largely through partner-bank surfaces and the institution's own Hong Kong app for read-only visibility. Client engagement flexibility permitted under the SFC's WMC guidance — including three-party arrangements with written client consent — governs advice ([Conventus Law, SFC circular 24EC6](#)).

Book C — Hong Kong Inbound Visitor (Segments 2, 6, 7, and non-migrated 1, 8, 9). Mainland residents who travel to Hong Kong. All acquisition and advice occur in Hong Kong; all pre-arrival digital activity is confined to general information, eligibility self-assessment, document preparation and appointment booking. Post-arrival, the client uses the full Hong Kong app. Post-sale servicing continues digitally.

The governing rule between books is that a client's book determines the permissible channel set, and the system must enforce this automatically rather than relying on staff judgement.

Part 8 — Channel architecture

The Hong Kong mobile app: sole system of record

Every transaction, every position, every advice record and every document lives in the Hong Kong-regulated app and its supporting core. No other surface holds state. The app must deliver, at minimum:

- Simplified-Chinese-first interface with traditional Chinese and English parity, and Mandarin-capable voice and chat service.
- Residency-aware onboarding with two distinct paths: HKID holders via iAM Smart or ePassport certificate remote eKYC; visitors via pre-arrival capture plus in-branch or in-centre activation.
- A cross-boundary transfer orchestrator that shows, per rail, the remaining capacity, the eligible purposes and the prohibited purposes — Payment Connect's HKD10,000 daily and HKD200,000 annual per-institution limits, the US\$50,000 FX facility with its exclusions, and correspondent alternatives ([HKMA](#)).

- Multi-currency accounts across HKD, USD, CNH, EUR, GBP and AUD with transparent conversion pricing and rate alerts.
- A rail-tagged product shelf: every product displays its permissible funding rails and blocks selection where no rail is available to that client's book.
- A tax and reporting centre generating per-transaction gain records, annual consolidated statements, CRS position summaries and after-tax illustrations.
- Household view with role-based permissioning covering spouse, adult children, second-generation decision-makers and family office staff, each with explicit consent records.
- Policy servicing for insurance held with partner insurers, including cash values, premium schedules, claim submission and status.
- Appointment and visit orchestration: branch, insurer signing, and document verification bookable in a single itinerary.

Competitor benchmarks establish the baseline. Hang Seng offers in-app cross-border view and transfer with fifteen-minute account opening ([Hang Seng](#)); Bank of China (Hong Kong) provides cross-border account opening plus BoC Pay ([BOCHK](#), [BOCHK](#)); ICBC (Asia) was first to Payment Connect ([ICBC Asia](#)); and ZA Bank is the only Hong Kong bank offering fully online Wealth Management Connect southbound participation without travel to Hong Kong ([ZA Bank](#)). WeLab Bank publishes an explicit mainland-visitor onboarding path ([WeLab Bank](#)), while Mox excludes non-Hong-Kong residents ([Mox](#)). The virtual banks have set the friction benchmark; incumbents have set the product-breadth benchmark. The target is to hold both.

WeChat: a service surface, not a funnel

The constraints are hard and should be accepted rather than tested. An overseas entity may register only a verified Service Account, at approximately US\$99 per year, limited to four broadcasts per month, with no native WeChat Pay, no Cards and Offers, and no Mini Shop; mainland financial categories require mainland licences; and payments for overseas entities run only through TenPay Global Checkout ([WeChat Wiki](#), [WeChat developer documentation](#)).

The decisive gate is advertising. Tencent Ads treats financial and banking categories as non-admissible for overseas advertisers, with an exception for certain overseas banks that have mainland branches, permitting brand promotion only, with no transactional content, subject to a signed undertaking ([Tencent Ads](#), [Tencent Ads industry qualifications](#)). Institutions without a mainland branch have no paid acquisition path on WeChat, and should stop planning as though they do.

WeChat Channels adds a further layer: a Financial Industry Convention effective 1 April 2026 requires verification, financial-education livestreams need pre-approved qualifications, and product recommendations, return guarantees and off-platform traffic diversion are prohibited ([Futu News](#)).

The resulting mandate for WeChat is narrow and still valuable:

- Brand presence and institutional credibility, matching HSBC's use of a Hong Kong WeChat Official Account ([HSBC](#)).

- Existing-client servicing: appointment reminders, document-ready notifications, policy anniversary alerts, branch information, service status.
- Deep links into the Hong Kong app for anything transactional, with the app as the only place authentication and transactions occur.
- Where a mainland branch exists, a Greater Bay Area appointment mini programme on the mainland entity, following the HSBC pattern of a WeChat mini programme with confirmation inside twenty-four hours ([HSBC China](#)).

WeChat is explicitly not a source of new-to-bank mainland-resident acquisition after 30 September 2026.

WeCom: servicing yes, advice no

This is the most consequential and least understood constraint in the entire channel plan. WeCom session content archiving is not available to overseas-registered WeCom entities; archiving requires a verified mainland entity ([Tencent WeCom help centre](#), [WeCom developer documentation](#)). A Hong Kong-entity WeCom therefore cannot be made compliance-recordable, and a mainland-entity WeCom imports the Circular 28 and NFRA Announcement No. 9 perimeter directly into the conversation. Overseas WeCom verification is priced at approximately RMB700 per year, restricted to small-enterprise scale, capped at five enterprises per entity, with customer groups limited to 500 members.

The resulting policy should be explicit and technically enforced:

1. **Permitted on WeCom:** identity-confirmed servicing of existing clients — appointment logistics, document requests, general market commentary already published and approved, service notifications, and directing clients into the app for anything substantive.
2. **Prohibited on WeCom:** product recommendation, suitability discussion, order taking, price quoting, and any communication that would constitute regulated advice or solicitation.
3. **Structural mitigation:** all substantive advice moves to recorded channels inside the app — in-app secure messaging with full retention, recorded voice or video calls, and, for Wealth Management Connect clients, three-party dialogues with the partner bank under written client consent renewed annually.
4. **Surveillance:** independent endpoint or desktop capture on staff devices for the Hong Kong WeCom tenant, plus lexicon-based monitoring, with documented acknowledgement that platform-native archiving is unavailable and compensating controls are in place.
5. **Contractual and training controls:** staff undertakings, mandatory attestation, and periodic testing, with disciplinary consequences for solicitation over WeCom.

The honest conclusion is that WeCom is a relationship-continuity and logistics tool, not an advice channel. Institutions that treat it as an advice channel are accumulating an unrecorded-communications problem that will surface in a regulatory review.

Xiaohongshu and content: brand only, geo-disciplined

Xiaohongshu is the leading research channel for the target cohort and has opened its first office outside the mainland in Hong Kong ([InvestHK](#)), with penetration reaching 62% in Hong Kong ([Marketing-Interactive](#)). Industry bodies have used it for insurance education ([AS1](#)).

The permissible use is narrow. Content targeted at Hong Kong residents, about Hong Kong life, banking practicalities, education and residency, is defensible. Content that markets overseas financial products to mainland residents is not, and NFRA Announcement No. 9's explicit prohibition on disguising marketing as investor education closes the obvious workaround. The rule for the content function should be that no mainland-resident-targeted content may describe a product, a return, or an account-opening path; permissible topics are the city, the rules as published by regulators, and the institution's brand.

The Hong Kong visit as a designed digital journey

This is the highest-return build in the plan and the least glamorous. The target is a single ninety-minute visit that produces a funded, activated, invested and insured relationship.

- **Pre-arrival, remote:** eligibility self-assessment by book; document checklist generated from the client's specific status; document upload and pre-verification; risk profiling and suitability questionnaire completion; product shortlisting subject to in-person confirmation; appointment booking with a guaranteed slot; travel and itinerary confirmation.
- **On arrival:** identity verification against pre-uploaded documents; account activation; source-of-funds declaration signed as required by SFC circular 26EC29; investment account activation; insurer signing appointment in the same building or a scheduled adjacent slot; app installation, biometric enrolment and first funding.
- **Post-visit:** digital servicing, policy views, tax reporting, and re-engagement without further travel.

The competitive context is that demand is queuing physically, with same-day ticket rationing at major branches. An institution that converts the queue into a booked, pre-verified appointment stream captures volume its competitors are actively turning away.

Partner rails

Three partnership sets are required. First, Wealth Management Connect mainland partner banks — the field is well populated, with HSBC offering 400-plus products, DBS operating three southbound partnerships and CMB Wing Lung running an established one-stop China model ([HSBC](#), [DBS](#), [Hubbiss](#)). Second, insurers, for policy data feeds, digital claims and co-located signing. Third, where a mainland presence exists, a GBA attestation or witnessing capability of the kind HSBC and Standard Chartered operate ([HSBC](#), [Standard Chartered](#)).

Part 9 — Product architecture

The shelf is organised by which need cluster it answers and which rail funds it.

Currency and payments — the scale layer

CNH and multi-currency deposits, transparent FX with tiered pricing, Payment Connect for small-value flows, and remittance orchestration. This layer is legally the safest and commercially the broadest: it serves seven of nine segments, requires no investment suitability process, and anchors the primary banking relationship. Offshore renminbi liquidity in Hong Kong of RMB1,134.7bn at end-May 2026 provides the funding base ([Nashnova](#)).

Wealth Management Connect southbound — the closed-loop layer

Deposits, money market funds, bond funds and non-complex Greater China equity funds, with a curated menu rather than a maximal one. The observed rotation from 98% deposits to 59% deposits, 36% funds and 5% bonds shows the migration path: acquire on deposit, convert to funds through digital education and self-service switching. The commercial insight from Segment 1 is that dormant WMC deposit balances are the cheapest available source of fund AUM in the market, and require servicing rather than acquisition spend.

Investment platform — the retention layer

Hong Kong and US equities, exchange-traded funds, mutual funds, bonds, structured products for eligible clients, gold in physical, paper and exchange-traded forms, and tokenised money market funds. Hong Kong's tokenised retail money market funds reached approximately US\$5.48bn across eight products, a 557% increase, and virtual asset spot exchange-traded funds approximately US\$5.47bn across eleven products ([HashKey and Bosera](#), [ChinaAMC Hong Kong](#)). Gold deserves explicit prominence given the +15% net intention reading, the strongest of any asset class.

Insurance — the highest-value layer, gated

Whole life, critical illness, medical and multi-currency savings, arranged through licensed Hong Kong intermediaries with in-person signing, plus a full post-sale digital servicing suite. The strategic posture should be to build the post-sale servicing platform now, on the assumption that pre-sale digitisation becomes available for talent-scheme migrants and overseas-resident PRC passport holders following the Insurance Authority's redefinition. Premium financing should be approached with caution given scrutiny in the market ([Business Times](#)).

Structuring, succession and family office — the depth layer

Trust review and establishment, will and probate coordination, family governance, family office set-up support, philanthropy, and private-market access for qualified clients. Demand is confirmed by the 3,384 Hong Kong single family offices and the RMB21 trillion ten-year transfer estimate. The digital contribution is diagnostic and event-driven rather than self-service.

Reporting and tax — the differentiating layer

Per-transaction offshore gain records aligned to the 20% IIT computation basis, consolidated annual statements, CRS position summaries, after-tax product illustrations, trust-related reporting under Announcement No. 21 of 2026, and insurance policy gain reporting. No competitor currently treats this as a product. It answers a need in five of nine segments and creates a switching cost that performance cannot.

Lending and property — the anchoring layer

Hong Kong mortgage pre-qualification for Book A residents, education-linked facilities, and secured lending against portfolio for eligible clients. Property is the most common reason a talent-scheme migrant chooses a primary bank, and the mortgage decision typically precedes the wealth decision.

Business banking — the flanking layer

Multi-currency corporate accounts, receivables and trade finance, API and accounting integration, and treasury yield products for Segment 9 and the corporate side of Segment 1. This is where the strongest legal footing coincides with the weakest incumbent service quality.

Part 10 — Data, AI and the compliance engine

The perimeter engine

A single service, invoked before any outbound communication or any product presentation, that evaluates four attributes — client book, verified residency, current location signal, and product rail eligibility — and returns a permit or deny with a logged rationale. Nothing reaches a client without passing through it. Specifically, it must block product marketing to a mainland-resident record, block WeCom messages containing product or advice lexicon, block investment product presentation where no funding rail is available, and enforce the two-year Circular 28 rectification posture for any legacy relationship that cannot be brought within the perimeter.

PIPL-constrained data architecture

Cross-border transfer of personal information out of the mainland requires a CAC security assessment, standard contractual clauses, or certification, with maximum penalties reaching RMB50m or 5% of turnover ([KPMG](#), [Arnold & Porter](#), [PCPD](#)). The practical design consequences are that the Hong Kong customer master must not ingest mainland-sourced personal data without a lawful transfer basis; consolidated cross-boundary views should be rendered client-side or through explicitly consented, minimised feeds; and marketing analytics must not profile mainland-resident individuals using mainland-sourced behavioural data.

AI and agentic operations

The regulatory environment is supportive on the Hong Kong side. The HKMA's Fintech 2030 agenda and its DART framework set the direction ([HKMA](#)); the Fintech Promotion Blueprint reports 95% fintech adoption, 97% regtech adoption and 75% AI adoption among banks, with agentic AI emerging in 2025 ([HKMA](#)); and GenA.I. Sandbox++ opened in March 2026 ([HKMA](#)), with HSBC already trialling real-time customer interaction in the sandbox ([HSBC](#)). OCBC's agentic AI deployment reduced private-banking onboarding to fifteen business days, which sets a concrete benchmark ([OCBC](#)).

Four AI applications are prioritised, in order of return:

1. **Document and onboarding automation** – extraction, verification and pre-adjudication of pre-arrival document packs, targeting same-visit activation.
2. **Event-driven advisory triggers** – detecting which clients hold structures, policies or positions affected by a rule change and generating relationship-manager tasks within days, addressing Segment 8's core complaint.
3. **Tax and reporting computation** – per-transaction gain calculation and statement generation at scale.
4. **Simplified-Chinese conversational service** – in-app assistant handling servicing queries, with hard guardrails preventing product recommendation and automatic escalation to a licensed human for anything advisory.

Part 11 – Roadmap

Wave 1 – Foundations, H2 2026 to Q1 2027

The objectives are to stop the compliance bleeding and fix the identity model.

- Stand up the perimeter engine and re-key the customer master on residency rather than nationality. Reclassify the existing mainland-origin base into Books A, B and C.
- Complete NFRA Announcement No. 9 readiness before 30 September 2026: audit and remediate all mainland-facing digital content, retire educational-content funnels, and re-scope the WeChat Service Account to brand and servicing only.
- Implement the WeCom policy with lexicon monitoring, endpoint capture and staff attestation; migrate all advice traffic into recorded in-app channels.
- Launch remote onboarding for HKID holders using iAM Smart, iAM Smart+ and ePassport-based certificates. This unlocks Book A immediately.
- Launch the pre-arrival journey and appointment orchestration for Book C, with guaranteed slots and pre-verified document packs.
- Ship the cross-boundary transfer orchestrator with per-rail quota visualisation, and complete the multi-currency and CNH deposit build.
- Begin the Wealth Management Connect dormant-balance reactivation programme: identify every southbound deposit-only account, deliver digital fund education and in-app

switching, and re-test family eligibility under the eased residency test.

Wave 2 — Depth, Q2 to Q3 2027

The objectives are to convert acquisition into wealth relationships.

- Launch the tax and reporting centre: per-transaction gain records, consolidated statements, CRS summaries and after-tax illustrations.
- Launch the CIES portfolio and reporting proposition as a designed product for Segment 5, including eligibility monitoring and immigration reporting automation.
- Launch household and family-role permissioning, addressing Segments 3, 5 and 8.
- Launch the insurance post-sale servicing suite — consolidated policy views, digital claims, premium orchestration — and pre-build pre-sale digital signing behind a feature flag, ready to activate if and when the Insurance Authority's MCV redefinition permits it.
- Launch the business banking proposition for Segment 9 with API access and treasury yield products, and link corporate onboarding to personal wealth onboarding.
- Deploy event-driven advisory triggers and the agentic onboarding pipeline; target same-visit activation as the standard rather than the exception.
- Add gold, tokenised money market funds and expanded US equity access to the investment shelf.

Wave 3 — Scale and optionality, Q4 2027

The objectives are to industrialise and to be positioned for the next policy opening.

- Scale the Hong Kong visit engine to a repeatable, capacity-managed operation across multiple centres, with service-level guarantees.
- Complete structuring and succession digitisation: diagnostics, structure health checks and family office onboarding workflows.
- Position for policy optionality: Wealth Management Connect expansion beyond the Greater Bay Area, new QDII quotas, MCV redefinition, and the Circular 28 rectification deadline in May 2028. Each should have a pre-built activation plan rather than a discovery project.
- Institutionalise the annual consent renewal cycle for three-party Wealth Management Connect dialogues and household permissions.

Part 12 — The end-2027 target state

By 31 December 2027 the following should be demonstrably true. These are design targets for the institution, set against the published baselines cited above; they are commitments to be managed, not forecasts of market outcomes.

Capability statements

Identity and books. Every mainland-origin client sits in exactly one of Books A, B or C, keyed on verified residency. No client can receive a communication or see a product that their book does not permit, because the perimeter engine enforces it in code and logs every decision.

Acquisition. The majority of new mainland-origin clients are acquired through a pre-arrival digital journey completed on Hong Kong soil in a single visit of ninety minutes or less, or fully remotely for HKID holders. No acquisition depends on a mainland-facing digital funnel.

Channels. The Hong Kong app is the sole system of record and the only transactional surface. The WeChat Service Account carries brand and existing-client servicing with zero transactional function and zero new-to-bank mainland-resident acquisition attribution. WeCom carries servicing and logistics only, with documented compensating surveillance controls and zero advice traffic, verified by testing.

Product. Every product in the catalogue carries an explicit funding-rail tag, and the interface prevents selection where no lawful rail exists for that client. Currency and payments carry volume; Wealth Management Connect funds carry closed-loop conversion; the investment platform carries retention; insurance servicing carries loyalty; reporting carries consolidation.

Advice. All regulated advice is delivered through recorded channels — in-app messaging, recorded calls, or three-party Wealth Management Connect dialogues under current written consent. Unrecorded advisory communication is treated as a reportable control breach.

Data. No mainland-sourced personal data enters the Hong Kong customer master without a documented lawful transfer basis. Consolidated cross-boundary views operate under explicit, renewable consent with data minimisation.

Quantified scorecard

Dimension	Baseline reference	End-2027 target
Book A — HKID-holding mainland-origin clients onboarded fully remotely	Capability not offered by most incumbents; more than 100,000 TTPS arrivals in the addressable pool	60% of all new Book A clients onboarded without a branch visit; Book A the largest of the three books by client count
Time to activated relationship, Book C	Same-day ticket rationing at approximately 60 per day at major branches	Single visit of 90 minutes or less, with accounts, investment account and app active before the client leaves
Onboarding cycle time, wealth tier	15 business days achieved with agentic AI by a regional peer	5 business days or fewer from pre-arrival submission to full activation
WMC southbound composition	Market mix 59% deposits / 36% funds / 5% bonds	Own book at 40% or less deposits, 50% or more funds and bonds, achieved primarily by reactivating dormant deposit accounts
WMC scheme context	More than 181,000 investors, more than RMB138bn remitted, approximately 11% southbound quota used	Own share of net new southbound investors in the top three among Hong Kong banks, with quota utilisation growth outpacing the scheme average

Dimension	Baseline reference	End-2027 target
Multi-currency and CNH	Hong Kong offshore RMB deposits RMB1,134.7bn	Multi-currency or CNH account held by 80% or more of all mainland-origin clients; FX and payments the top contributor to cross-border non-interest income
Insurance servicing	Post-sale servicing largely manual and courier-based; MCV data series suspended since Q1 2025	100% of in-force partner policies visible in-app; digital claim submission for all standard claim types; pre-sale digital signing live within 90 days of any Insurance Authority permission
Tax and reporting	No incumbent offers this as a product	Per-transaction gain reporting, CRS summaries and after-tax illustrations available to all clients; cited as a top-three reason for consolidation in client research
CIES proposition	3,166 applications, 1,762 approvals, approximately HK\$95bn expected inflow	Designed CIES portfolio-and-reporting product live with automated eligibility monitoring; measurable share of new CIES approvals in the period
Household relationships	Not modelled by most institutions	40% or more of wealth-tier relationships include at least one permissioned second household member
Digital servicing self-sufficiency	Bain: 46% of problem resolution human-led	70% or more of servicing interactions resolved digitally; advice remains deliberately human-led
Compliance	Circular 28 rectification deadline approximately May 2028	Zero unrecorded-advice findings; zero mainland-resident product marketing findings; rectification of all legacy non-conforming relationships complete a full year before the deadline

What will not be true by end-2027

Honesty about limits is part of the plan. Mainland-resident clients will not be acquirable through a digital funnel; that path is closed and the strategy does not assume it reopens. Pre-sale insurance digitisation for mainland visitors will not be available unless the Insurance Authority's redefinition is finalised in the client's favour, so it is built behind a flag rather than in the business case. Wealth Management Connect will not extend beyond the Greater Bay Area on any committed timetable, so no revenue plan should depend on it. And the US\$50,000 personal FX facility will remain unusable for securities and life insurance, so no product should be designed as though retail onshore savings can fund it.

Part 13 — Risks, dependencies and triggers

Risk or dependency	Assessment	Trigger and response
Circular 28 interpretation tightens further, or reverse enquiry is narrowed	Unresolved and material	Maintain the perimeter engine as the single point of change; a tightening should be a configuration update, not a re-platforming
Insurance Authority MCV redefinition is delayed or excludes the target cohorts	Consultation was slated for Q2 2026 with guidelines within 2026	Insurance pre-sale digitisation built behind a feature flag, no revenue attributed until permission is confirmed

Risk or dependency	Assessment	Trigger and response
Further Hong Kong-side account tightening under 26EC29 successors	Banks tightened within days of the May 2026 circular	Over-invest in source-of-funds documentation quality; make the declaration workflow a strength rather than a friction point
PIPL enforcement against consolidated cross-boundary views	Penalties up to RMB50m or 5% of turnover	Client-side rendering and consented minimised feeds by default; no speculative data ingestion
WeCom archiving remains unavailable to overseas entities	Confirmed current state	Compensating surveillance plus an enforced no-advice policy; do not build advice workflows on WeCom under any circumstances
Tax enforcement suppresses offshore demand	Enforcement extended to insurance gains and trusts during 2026	Reposition reporting and after-tax analysis as the product; demand shifts from concealment to compliance support rather than disappearing
Competitive response from virtual banks on friction	ZA Bank already offers fully online WMC southbound	Match onboarding friction while retaining product breadth; friction parity is the minimum viable position
Mobility cohort policy change	TTPS and CIES are policy-dependent	Diversify across TTPS, QMAS, CIES and student cohorts rather than concentrating on one scheme

Part 14 — Evidence limitations

Several gaps should be stated rather than papered over. Mainland visitor insurance premium data is unavailable for 2025 and 2026 because the Insurance Authority suspended the disaggregated series from Q1 2025, so the HK\$62.8bn FY2024 figure is the most recent authoritative reading. The finest-grained occupational segmentation available is the 2023 Bain & China Merchants Bank edition; no confirmed 2025 successor was located. No Wealth Management Connect 3.0 has been announced, and expansion beyond the Greater Bay Area remains discussion rather than policy. QDLP quota allocations are not publicly disclosed. Reliable population and wealth figures for a distinct creator-economy or private-credit segment were not found, so no segment was constructed for them. Greater Bay Area insurance after-sales service centres are described in policy materials but their operational status was not independently confirmed. Any figure in this report derived by arithmetic from published aggregates rather than published directly should be treated as an estimate, and household-count and wealth figures date from the start of 2025 and will have moved.